

Westminster and Works

A Calvinistic Perspective

by

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A disconcerting tension has existed for a time in the minds of some concerning a certain paradox - only a *seeming* contradiction, of course - which appears to be inherent in the very nature of our British Reformed Fellowship. It can be formulated thus. The B.R.F. desires simultaneously to endorse and advocate a view of the covenant which generally parallels that constructed by Herman Hoeksema on the basis of Scripture, and maintain a favourable position toward the Westminster Standards, which are interpreted as containing an entirely different conception of the covenant, especially with regard to the pre-fall 'covenant of works.' It is my purpose in this article to demonstrate from the actual wording of the Standards that, while it may be true that Hoeksema goes *beyond* the teaching of Westminster when dealing with the covenant of works, his theology at no point *contradicts* what the Confession actually states. Further, I will argue that the covenantal view championed in some Presbyterian circles as the creedal view, is in fact in serious conflict with some of the most basic statements the Confession makes.

The essential point of conflict centres around the idea of *merit*. Was Adam before his fall into sin able to merit the favour of Jehovah? Hoeksema brought the charge against Charles Hodge,¹ even though Hodge nowhere uses the word.² Hodge does, however, make it plain that it was eternal or heavenly life which was promised Adam as a reward of obedience. However, Hodge's son does use the word, treating merit and reward as synonyms, obviously oblivious to the important distinction between the two in the Reformed tradition.³ Earlier, Shaw had argued that if Adam had fulfilled the condition of obedience, he would actually have had the right to demand the promise of eternal life from God.⁴ In the same century MacPherson likewise said that God would have been under obligation to give Adam life, if he had fulfilled the terms and passed the probation by his own natural

1. *Reformed Dogmatics*, p. 217.

2. *Systematic Theology*, Vol. 2, pp. 117-122.

3. A. A. Hodge, *The Confession of Faith*, p. 122. Compare with the Heidelberg Catechism, Quest. no. 63.

4. *The Reformed Faith: An Exposition of the Confession of Faith of the Westminster Assembly of Divines*, p. 84.

strength.⁵ ‘The Sum of Saving Knowledge’ similarly talks about God being ‘bound’ by His ‘contract’ with Adam. I want to argue that the Westminster Standards, directly and indirectly, teach the very opposite. Here are some of the doctrinal emphases on the surface of Westminster which overtly contradict all this.

First, the independence or aseity of God. ‘God hath all life, glory, goodness, blessedness, in and of Himself; and is alone in and unto Himself all-sufficient, not standing in need of any creatures which He hath made, nor deriving any glory from them, but only manifesting His own glory in, by, unto, and upon them.’⁶ God is in no sense correlative to or dependent on anything outside Himself, is sufficient unto Himself and free outside Himself, existing beyond all cause and source. He is self-sufficient fullness, able to give and never to receive. Nothing can be given to the One who has and is all, so nothing can constrain or bind the living God.

Because of this, God’s relations to men are only and ever based on God’s pleasure, never His need. God did not need Adam’s obedience or righteousness in order for Him to be able to give Adam continued life. Likewise God did not need Adam’s sin and disobedience in order for God to reveal Himself to Adam as gracious, or the dispenser of free and unmerited favour. Grace is an attribute or characteristic of God, and because of divine simplicity, *is God*. Therefore God was grace of, through and in Himself toward Adam even before the fall, for God cannot deny Himself, and could be nothing other to Adam than He eternally is in Himself.

Second, the condition of man at creation. ‘After God had made all other creatures, he created man, male and female, with reasonable and immortal souls, endued with knowledge, righteousness, and true holiness, after His own image.’⁷ Adam was only capable of reflecting or imaging the righteousness of God which God had already given him, or endued him with, as a gift. Merit only makes sense if defined as an original feature or quality which by its own worth is deserving of praise. But the righteousness possessed by Adam did in no way originate with or from him. Both in his initial creation and in the continued course of his life, Adam was immediately dependent on the Triune God to uphold him in His image providentially. And any promise or reward rendered to Adam in Eden could not be grounded on something earned, but something freely given, even as the original creation was free and gratuitous.

Third, the covenantal freedom of God. The main doctrine of the covenant expounded by the Westminster Standards is to be found in chapter seven of the Confession, and is divided into six parts. Part two deals with the pre-fall covenant, and parts three to six with the covenant of grace. But it is the beautiful and key first part which concerns me. In it, a general covenantal definition and pattern is posited which is structurally applicable to all the revelations or administrations of the one

5. *The Confession of Faith*, p. 66.

6. *Westminster Confession of Faith*, chapter two, section two.

7. *Westminster Confession of Faith*, chapter four, section two.

covenant of God which is referred to in the chapter title. The fulfilment of the covenant relation is for the creature to have God 'as their blessedness and reward.' Note that this is as true of God's covenant with Adam as with us. God Himself, and communion with Him, is all the 'reward' the righteous need or want, both now and always. But the way in which the covenant relation is brought about is by means of God's 'voluntary condescension.' All notions of God's being bound or forced to give reward to Adam are, in this one phrase, utterly annihilated. All rewards given, or to be expected, in any of God's covenantal dealings with men, are necessarily granted only on God's initiative, and by God's free and unconditional pleasure.

More amazing are some of the biblical texts used by the Westminster divines here to prove this doctrine. Among them is Luke 17 v. 10, in which Christ compares men to a servant who deserves no rewards or even thanks from his Master, and is still unprofitable even when, as Adam in Eden, he continually performs all his duty and fully obeys every commandment. What is amazing, to me at least, is that this very text has been used by Protestant Reformed ministers for years to prove exactly the same point as the Confession; namely, that man as a creature, even apart from sin or the breaking of the Master's law, could never merit with God, because 'the distance between God and the creature is so great,' as the Confession puts it.⁸ All man does is to 'owe obedience to Him as their Creator.' They are incapable of more, just because of their creaturehood.⁹ After the fall God's grace is positively *demerited*, but before the fall and sin it was still *unmerited*, and the Confession makes no mention of sin in this first section.

Fourth, the necessity of the incarnation. *Cur Deus Homo?* Why did God have to become man? Would a holy angel not have done, or even a sinless human person? The Larger Catechism addresses this important question in answer thirty-eight. One of the main reasons given by the Westminster divines was that '**worth and efficacy**' had to be given to the obedience of the Mediator according to His human nature. In other words, if the Christ had not been divine, no sufficient value or power would be found by God in the acts of obedience He performed in order for Him to be able to merit heavenly things with God, or to '**procure his favour**.' The first human was of the earth, earthy, and naturally incapable of progressing beyond. **The second man is the divine Lord from heaven, and is thus uniquely able to take His people there, which the first was not able to do.**¹⁰ Because of this biblical fact, it is not possible to view the first and second Adam as standing in a symmetrical or parallel relation. By his obedience, the first could only gain the sort of life he already possessed, both for him and his, because of what he was. How could a natural and terrestrial being earn that which was spiritual and celestial? Only a divine-man, or God incarnate, could do that.

8. See, for example, Herman Hoeksema, *Reformed Dogmatics*, p. 218. Also Herman Hanko, *God's Everlasting Covenant of Grace*, p. 31.

9. Observe particularly the following texts quoted by the Confession, Job 22 vs. 2-3 and Job 35 vs 7-8.

10. I Corinthians ch. 15 vs. 45-49.

Fifth, the nature of eternal life. Inexorably intertwined with the view of the covenant of works I have been arguing against is the notion not only that Adam could have *merited*, but that he could have merited *eternal life*. Of course, the Standards have exactly the same amount to say about each, that is, **nothing**. Following the Scripture, which defines eternal life as the knowledge of the only true God, whose Son is Jesus Christ,¹¹ the Westminster divines find the essence of eternal or spiritual life as union and communion with Christ, now by grace and afterward in glory.¹² By this gracious union they are spiritually and mystically, yet really and inseparably joined to Christ their head. This is the chief and most special benefit enjoyed by the church.¹³ They are united to God in Christ, and are partakers of the *divine* nature,¹⁴ for no human one would suffice. It is a truly Trinitarian affair. The Spirit works faith in us to unite us in and to the Son of the Father as a society of believers.¹⁵

If Adam the human could have earned his grace (as much a contradiction in terms as speech about square circles!) before the fall, hypothetically our picture is radically altered to deformity. Adam can enter heaven outside and without the Christ whom to know is heavenly life. God is made bound to respect and reward the righteous Adam for doing what he was told, and so Adam boldly and autonomously marches into heaven by himself. Adam enjoys a 'heaven' apart from union with the 'sent' Son of God. Could Adam then unite himself to the invisible and unapproachable God without a divine-human Mediator? He would certainly have to do this if he were to enjoy eternal life at all. The only alternative to this monstrous picture is that God had always intended to allow the fall, and send His Son to give His people eternal life, and that any talk of anything else is superfluous speculation, something that the Westminster divines did not indulge in.

These views are not unique to the present writer. Two examples of commentators on the Westminster Confession who agree with him will be cited as evidence. First, G.I. Williamson, commenting on chapter seven, says that, 'all God's covenant dealings with men are both gracious and sovereign. They are imposed by the will of God, and not the will of man.' He also states that God is not bound by man as a party of the covenant, that sinless obedience cannot earn anything from God, and that man before the fall could not have merited God's blessing.¹⁶

11. John ch. 17 v. 3.

12. Larger Catechism, no. 65.

13. Larger Catechism, no. 66.

14. II Peter ch. 1 v. 4.

15. Shorter Catechism, no. 30. Also, Heidelberg Catechism, no. 76.

16. *The Westminster Confession of Faith for Study Classes*, pp. 63-64. Readers might also be interested to learn that Herman Hoeksema is being specifically and favourably quoted by contemporary Reformed theologians with regard to his covenant conception. See, for example, the following, *The Theological Basis for Covenanting* by Frederick Leahy, pp. 7, 9, 12; *The Christian Philosophy of Education Explained* by Stephen Perks, p. 53; and *The Institutes of Biblical Law* by Rousas Rushdoony, p. 14.

Secondly, Rowland S. Ward, commenting on the same chapter, defines covenants made by God with men as 'sworn promises in terms set by God in his sovereignty and grace. The word contract or compact is not a suitable synonym.' 'On the basis of his deeds man never can earn God's favour.' Ward prefers the term 'covenant of life' as used by the Shorter Catechism, rather than 'covenant of works,' because it 'avoids the idea of eternal life as meritorious reward.'¹⁷

In holding these views I believe we in the British Reformed Fellowship are, along with the Westminster divines, closer to the position of the sixteenth century Calvin, than that of the nineteenth century Calvinists. To prove this I will briefly conclude by examining Calvin himself. Before I do this, however, one point has to be made. Some might object to my quotations from Calvin as being invalid because the context is one of justification from guilt, and sin is thus presupposed. I answer, first, that none of the quotes mentions sin, and secondly, that it is clear from the meaning of the quotes that Calvin intends them to be applicable to man as man, as much as to man as sinner.

Calvin deplores even the word 'merit,' because 'being a high sounding term, it can only obscure the grace of God, and inspire men with pernicious pride.'¹⁸ A perfect and biblical understanding of obedience can be attained without its use. 'All the Apostles abound in exhortations, admonitions, and rebukes, for the purpose of training the man of God *to every good work*, and that without any mention of merit.'¹⁹ Calvin derides those who 'absurdly infer merit from reward.'²⁰ Good works, by definition, are ever only to perform our duty, due to merit. 'We do not perform gratuitous duties, but pay Him service which is due . . . let us not boast of voluntary liberality in matters of necessary obligation.'²¹

All the meritorious and righteous standing before God for any man must always and only be in the divine Christ. 'Our righteousness is offensive in the sight of God unless it derives a sweet odour from the piety of Christ.'²² We can only merit by 'participation in him,' and by being 'ingrafted into Christ.'²³ As always, Calvin's primary concern is for the being and attributes or virtues of God. 'To whatever extent *any man* rests in himself, to the same extent he impedes the beneficence of God.'²⁴ 'The righteousness of God is not sufficiently displayed, unless He alone is held to be righteous, and freely communicates righteousness to the undeserving. . . . *Whosoever* imagines he had anything of his own, rebels against God, and obscures His glory.'²⁵ 'Everything in our works which deserves praise is owing to

17. *The Westminster Confession for the Church Today*, pp. 59-61.

18. *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, 3:15:2. All italics mine.

19. *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, 3:16:3.

20. *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, 3:16:2.

21. *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, 3:14:14.

22. *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, 3:14:16.

23. *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, 3:15:5.

24. *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, 3:12:8.

25. *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, 3:13:1.

divine grace, and that there is not a particle of it which we can properly ascribe to ourselves. If we truly and seriously acknowledge this, not only confidence, but every idea of merit vanishes. . . . Should the Lord, therefore, bring to judgment *the best of human works*, he would indeed behold his own righteousness in them.²⁶

Such a strong affirmation of the truth that man as a creature can never merit with God is probably the most offensive proposition that could ever confront the modern mind. It is therefore good and should be preached. Our contemporary society is full of pride and obsessed with its own concocted 'rights.' It needs to be humbled into the dust and this is the doctrine to do it. Some theologians seem to want to give in to depraved society by inventing hypothetical scenarios in which it might have been possible for Adam to say to God, 'I have a right to eternal life and your favour. I have obeyed. You owe me!' They seem to forget that only a sovereign God has rights, and that man has only obligations. And even they are a gift.

As the foregoing article may present what is a hitherto unfamiliar position to some of our readers, we specially invite letters of discussion on the matter in order to clarify any of the points raised herein. *Editor.*

Jesus having entered heaven, and being seated at the right hand of God for us, proves the penalty is paid, sin for ever put away, and righteousness wrought out and brought in; but, perhaps, some will say, Did Jesus go to heaven by the way you have described, as the way for sinners? yes, for he went for sinners; so there was no other way for him, he being our surety, representative and head, and bearing our sins and acting for us. Oh ! amazing love ! astonishing condescension ! that our glorious, righteous, covenant-head, rather than his body, his church, his bride, should miss of glory everlasting, took all her sins upon himself, and went through hell with them, to consume them by suffering that eternal weight of punishment that was due to them, and so completely removed all sin, and every stain of sin from his body the church, performed her duty for her, rose triumphant from the conflict, manifested an eternal weight of glory for his church, entered heaven for her, and opened himself as the way to heaven for her by grace, he suffered, they escape; and in consequence of this gracious work for them in pursuance of his eternal choice of them, and purposes of love towards them, according to the good pleasure of his will;—he, by the Spirit, in the time-still of their being, awakens them to a sense of their wretched undone state in their fallen head Adam, to make room for the manifestation of himself to them, as the Lord their righteousness.

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26. Institutes of the Christian Religion, 3:15:3.